Writers - April '07 Word count: 593
ESTELLE EL-HAI

TWO DEADLY SINS

That's right; I, the pure and righteous Estelle Marilyn El-Hai, whose name means, "The Living Goddess", went off the beaten track, and committed not one, but two "sins". I put that in quotes because I really, really don't believe they were evil sins, but they were something I had never done before in my whole glorified life. And they did make me feel a little strange and watchful.

It happened last Monday night, on the eve of Passover. I had made a terrific seder, a traditional Passover dinner, for some relatives the night before. Although it was not actually the beginning of the holiday yet, it was the only day that my family could get here without worrying about missing work or school. So we bent it like Beckham. That has nothing to do with the sin part because the dinner was delicious and the ceremony went very well.

The questionable part was the timing and the situation. I had dinner at the Lodge on the eve of an important holiday, ate food that was absolutely not sanctioned by observant Jewish people, and I did this with a MARRIED MAN !! Don't be shocked; it was extremely platonic. His wife was away on a two week trip (I actually like her more than I do her husband), and he said he was lonely. Nice line? Well, I checked with another friend who knew him for many years, who said that she went with him, with her husband's blessing, to Thunder Valley because he was forlorn and needed cheering up. So why didn't he go on the wonderful trip with his wife, I inquired? Answer: His health condition did not permit it.

Mentally, I felt OK with my decision to share dinner with him, although I insisted on dutch treat to make sure there would be no misinterpretations. The one thing I was concerned about was not meeting any members of the Jewish Fellowship because that would make me uncomfortable. They probably would be uneasy as well, so I thought.

As soon as I ordered my drink, the first incident occurred. I was explaining to the waitress how to make an iced coffee (she had never heard of this drink, so popular on the east coast), when the first Jewish couple appeared. We waved hello across the room, and smiled weakly. I told my Catholic companion, that I hoped there would not be another friend of the Hebrew persuasion in the restaurant. Three other couples of the aforesaid persuasion, joyfully visited our table and asked me how I liked my dinner, and who was my friend? One of them, in an overly friendly way, sat down at our table and made some conversation, and inquiries.

My dinner comrade seemed amused when they left and confessed that his first wife was Jewish, and thought the whole thing was quite comical. I expect that the evening's events will be written up in the Courier and the Hebrew National Enquirer.

Luckily, we had to leave after two hours because my friend couldn't, or shouldn't, drive when it's dark. The wife in question is now home from her Asian trip and will re-hash the events with me at our coming Red Hat luncheon. I was told that I performed a favor for a nice man in need. I sent him home with some matzo to share with my friend, his wife.

I don't think I was a sinner, do you?

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